

THE DANDI MARCH

The Salt Satyagraha and the Catalyst of Indian Independence

Dates:	March 12, 1930 – April 6, 1930	Leader:	Mahatma Gandhi
Route:	Sabarmati Ashram to Dandi, Gujarat	Distance:	240 miles (385 km)

1. Historical Context and Background

In late 1929, the Indian National Congress promulgated the historic *Purna Swaraj* (Complete Independence) declaration at its Lahore session under the presidency of Jawaharlal Nehru. To translate this declaration into mass political action, the Congress Working Committee vested Mahatma Gandhi with full authority to launch a Non-Violent Civil Disobedience Campaign.

Gandhi chose salt as the focal point of the civil disobedience movement. Under the British Salt Act of 1882, the British Crown exercised a strict monopoly on the manufacture and sale of salt in India. Salt was subjected to a heavy taxation system, rendering it disproportionately expensive for the impoverished masses. Because salt was a basic daily necessity for every Indian regardless of caste, creed, religion, or income, Gandhi identified it as the perfect symbol to unite a fractured nation against colonial exploitation.

240 MILES WALKED	24 DAYS DURATION	78 INITIAL MARCHERS	60,000+ ARRESTS NATIONWIDE
----------------------------	----------------------------	-------------------------------	---

2. The Journey from Sabarmati to Dandi

On March 12, 1930, Gandhi set out from his Sabarmati Ashram near Ahmedabad accompanied by 78 trusted ashram members (Satyagrahis). The march spanned 240 miles across the rural heartland of Gujarat, passing through dozens of villages over 24 days.

Along the route, tens of thousands of citizens gathered to hear Gandhi speak. He addressed local assemblies daily, preaching the principles of *Satyagraha* (truth-force and non-violence), economic self-reliance through homespun cloth (khadi), the abolition of untouchability, and the imperative to refuse cooperation with British taxation. As the march progressed, the procession grew several miles long, attracting international journalists, photographers, and political observers.

"The British power is built on violence, and if we are to defeat it, we must match their physical force with soul-force. With this salt, I am shaking the foundations of the British Empire."

— Mahatma Gandhi, April 1930

3. Chronology of Events

Date	Event / Milestone
March 2, 1930	Gandhi sends an ultimatum letter to Viceroy Lord Irwin, outlining 11 demands and announcing his intent to break the Salt Laws if ignored.
March 12, 1930	The Dandi March officially begins from Sabarmati Ashram with 78 designated Satyagrahis.
April 5, 1930	The marching column arrives at the coastal village of Dandi, Gujarat, after covering 240 miles.
April 6, 1930	At 6:30 AM, Gandhi picks up a lump of natural salt from the mud at Dandi, breaking the British salt law and launching national Civil Disobedience.
May 4, 1930	Gandhi is arrested in the middle of the night at Karadi and incarcerated at Yerwada Central Jail without trial.
May 21, 1930	The Dharasana Salt Works raid occurs; non-violent protesters led by Sarojini Naidu face severe police beatings, generating global outcry.

4. Immediate Impact and Global Resonance

The act of breaking the salt law triggered widespread civil disobedience across India:

- **Mass Participation:** Millions of coastal residents made illegal salt, while inland communities openly bought and sold contraband salt.
- **Widespread Boycotts:** The movement expanded to include the boycott of foreign textiles, liquor shops, and imperial institutions. Village officials resigned in large numbers.
- **Women in the Movement:** Under leaders like Sarojini Naidu, Kasturba Gandhi, and Kamala Nehru, thousands of women stepped into public political life for the first time, leading pickets and marches.
- **International Coverage:** Foreign press outlets, notably *TIME Magazine* and American journalist Webb Miller, reported extensively on British police brutality against non-violent Satyagrahis, severely damaging Britain's international moral standing.

POLITICAL LEGACY: THE GANDHI-IRWIN PACT (1931)

The Civil Disobedience Movement brought colonial administration to a near standstill in several provinces. Incapable of curbing the non-violent agitation despite arresting over 60,000 people, Viceroy Lord Irwin initiated direct negotiations with Gandhi. This culminated in the Gandhi-Irwin Pact of March 1931, leading to the release of political prisoners, the permission for coastal villagers to produce salt for local consumption, and Indian representation at the Second Round Table Conference in London.

5. Historical Significance

The Dandi March transformed the Indian independence struggle from an elite nationalist debate into a true mass movement. By choosing a universally understood commodity—salt—Gandhi demystified anti-colonial resistance and demonstrated the strategic power of non-violent resistance. The Salt Satyagraha proved that moral authority and mass non-cooperation could effectively challenge the infrastructure of a global empire.